

Accent

Musical tones may be played with a varying degree of emphasis, or force. Accents are executed by vocalists and wind players with stronger air; string and keyboard performers use heavier arm or hand motions to produce a weightier tone. Here are the various symbols for different types of accented notes.



80

△ Martellato

This is a hammered, short, and fierce note. It is produced on a string instrument by holding and striking the bow against the string with force.



81

△ Marcato

Marcato, or "accent mark," means that performers should emphasize the note more than the surrounding tones through extra volume or weight.



82

△ Sforzando

This indicates that the performer should strike the note hard with a sudden force, and back away quickly.



83

△ Tenuto

A straight line over or under the notehead implies that performers should take care to hold the note for its full value.

Expression in action

Composers use expressive markings to distinguish notes and phrases. Slurs, staccatos, rests, and different types of accents are indicated to help the performer create interest and drama, such as in this thrilling march excerpt.

ff

mf

p

F# is marked with an accent mark, as a surprising note not in the key.

The martellato is marked over the note on the second beat of the measure to give emphasis to the beginning of the phrase.

This tie shows that the note should be sustained for the duration of both note-values added together.

This slur provides a smooth ending to an otherwise briskly separated phrase.

△ *The Charlatan*

This excerpt is from the piccolo part of *The Charlatan March* by American march composer/bandleader John Philip Sousa. He composed it using themes from his 1898 operetta "The Charlatan," or "The Mystical Miss."